



From opportunity to advantage: how firms can leverage generative AI affordances to drive success in competitive markets

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Technological opportunism

Generative AI

Competitive intensity

Competitive advantages

Affordance theory

ABSTRACT

Although firms with a proactive technology stance are increasingly adopting generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) to enhance competitiveness, integrating GenAI into business operations presents significant challenges. To address this dilemma, we ground in affordance theory to explore how firms can leverage GenAI affordances to transform technological opportunism (TO) into sustained competitive advantages, particularly in highly competitive environments. We draw on survey data from 223 firms spanning different industries in China and find that three GenAI affordances—organizational memory, collaborative, and creational affordances—mediate the relationship between TO and competitive advantages. Moreover, competitive intensity amplifies the mediation effect of creational affordance instead of the mediation effects of organizational memory and collaborative affordances. We add to the extant AI-driven business literature by emphasizing the mechanisms behind the TO–competitive advantages link from the perspective of GenAI affordances. Lastly, our findings provide practical guidance for managers aiming to harness GenAI effectively.

1. Introduction

In today's rapidly evolving, technology-driven business environment, adopting a proactive stance toward identifying and leveraging emerging technologies is increasingly critical (Bendig et al., 2023). This proactive stance, commonly referred to as technological opportunism (TO), is not merely about awareness of new technologies but entails a deliberate, forward-looking approach to seeking and applying emerging technological advancements (Lucia-Palacios et al., 2016). Theoretically, firms characterized by TO are well-positioned to seize new opportunities and adapt to evolving market conditions (Bullini Orlandi et al., 2020). However, the transition from TO to achieving sustained competitive advantage is fraught with challenges and complexities (Chen and Lien, 2013). A recent report indicates that 30 % of technology-driven projects are abandoned after the proof-of-concept stage (Gartner, 2024). This finding suggests that merely recognizing TO does not ensure success; firms must effectively deploy and integrate these technologies into their strategic frameworks.

As generative artificial intelligence (GenAI) emerges as a transformative force (Baabdullah, 2024), many firms with high TO actively adopt this technology (Mariani and Dwivedi, 2024). However, these firms also face significant challenges. For example, although GenAI has the potential to revolutionize product development, marketing, and customer interaction (Kshetri et al., 2024), integrating it into existing technological infrastructures often demands substantial investment and process reconfiguration (Fosso Wamba et al., 2023). Furthermore, although GenAI provides valuable insights for decision-making and strategy (Chowdhury et al., 2024), the key challenge lies not only in generating these insights but also in translating them into actionable strategies (Cook et al., 2024). Therefore, to fully capitalize on technological opportunities and sustain competitive advantages, it is essential to understand how firms can embed GenAI into their business processes.

We draw on affordance theory to examine how firms characterized by TO leverage GenAI (Sesay et al., 2024). Specifically, affordance refers to the perceived and actual properties of an object or environment that shape how it can be used or interacted with (De Luca et al., 2021).

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<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jbusres.2026.115974>

Received 2 March 2025; Received in revised form 2 January 2026; Accepted 3 January 2026

Available online 10 January 2026

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